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‘Jangi Laat’
Becoming the Army Chief

Chandigarh, 28 November 2004

When the government announced my name as the next chief of army staff on 27 November 2004, it made headline news. It was the first time in the history of the Indian Army that a Sikh officer was going to head it. It was indeed a great honour and a unique privilege. The Command House at Chandi Mandir Cantonment was brimming over with the media, who were keen to pick my mind on various issues. The first was, ‘How does it feel to be the first Sikh chief of the Indian Army?’

‘I consider myself first and last to be an Indian,’ was my immediate response. I added that I was proud to be a Sikh, and equally a Maratha, as I had spent over forty years with the Marathas. I carefully fended off many other queries by saying that the people must wait (I was still the army commander of Western Command), and give me time to reflect on my new position and responsibilities.

While narrating one of my poignant experiences in Kashmir, my eyes were moist, thinking of the intense pain and anguish of the innocent people in strife-torn areas. ‘These young Kashmiri boys did not deserve to die like this,’ I said, describing operations in Kashmir during which many AK-47-toting young men had lost their lives. I also recounted the story of the newly married misguided youth whom we let go after confiscating his AK-47. We gave him a chance to reform and start life afresh. There has to be a human touch while